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The Iron Crown II

Part I

The Desolation of Xion is not on common maps of the region. The area south of the northern pinnacles, bounded on the east by the Reasha sea, and north of the Drugge river is simply marked with slashes, across the parchment. Of course, nothing will stop the merchants, tradesmen, and desperate wanderers from crossing even the most hostile of environments.

There exists, therefore, a small, rather secretive market for handmade maps of the Desolation. Finding someone willing to part with one is hard though, and the prices they charge would send most of my profession into spiraling debt, and eventually slavery.

I opted for a different route. I stole a map from a group of traders who were just passing out of the region. This wasn't a choice made out of empathy, but of practicality. By the time they next looked for the map, I would be long gone.

I soon discovered that the map only marked a few relevant landmarks for crossing the land safely, and did not even show consistent roads, much less the locations of former cities.

Which is how I found myself hobbling up to towering gatehouse of the capital city, sixteen kilometers from the nearest road, and dropping to the ground as my leg gave up on holding my weight. It had been days since I had felt safe enough to sleep more than an hour.

Any semblance of a door, or even a doorway had crumbled to dust. Only the twin guardian towers still watched the entrance to the city. Thorn vines, living and dead, covered the fallen rocks around the towers, spreading across the path.

Xion. Once the pinnacle of civilization east of the Whitespine Mountains. A trading hub famed for its minerals and seafood. Arbiter of the most powerful army on the continent. Now a ghost story told to children to make them behave.

While waiting for my leg to return to its normal, semi-functional state, I opened up my cane and took out the architecture sketches I had acquired from a fellow researcher, replacing them with the map. I had little intention of using the map again, but there was no point in wasting it.

I had expected some level of disrepair in the city, but what I found was more pebbles than buildings. Even the iron and steel fences, which should have lasted for centuries, had rusted away, leaving dull gray dust and red streaks on the surrounding stones.

The air around me felt cold, dry, and remarkably still. The rustling grass, which had been a constant presence on the plains outside, was eerily absent within the walls.

Identifying a building using a sketch in this mess would be harder than finding a needle in a shellpile. Most buildings were nothing more than stones piled on the ground. Only a few, sheltered from the storms, had standing walls, and none had a roof.

Rather than continue my hopeless search, I turned towards the center of the city, where the palace was said to have been placed atop the hill.

Walking past a garden, ringed by metal posts that once formed an ornate fence, my bad leg caught on a hidden steel hook poking out of a crevice. I stumbled against the posts, barely catching myself.

In the center of the garden, a statue of a man, remarkably preserved, stood hunched over a small fountain, which dripped with what must be the last water left in the city. Despite the ragged clothes on the statue, an iron crown rested on its head, as if this was not a visage of a commoner, but of a king. Around the statue, columns stood in a circle, covered in vines.

I rested for a moment, then turned to continue upwards. Something cracked behind me. I spun around, searching for the source of the noise, and found a piece of clean marble at the base of the statue. Had it fallen from the columns?

I approached to pick it up, and found that one of the statue's hands held more marble pieces. I touched the hand, and another fell. *Nothing more than stones settling*, I thought.

I continued upwards, hopelessly checking ruin after ruin against my sketches. Nothing matched. The first sun was starting to set over the plains. As it crept lower, the light slowly changed from the deep orange cast to the silvery blue of the second sun.

It took an hour to reach the plateau at the top of the hill. Ashen stumps lined a shattered roadway leading up to what must have been the palace gatehouse.

At the front, two statues guarded the broken down entrance. Both held swords, and both, curiously, were adorned with iron crowns. I paused for a moment to stare at them. Their heads had been positioned perfectly to stare at visitors entering the palace. I shuddered, and continued into the ruins.

I found a secluded corner amid the rocks and began to set up camp. There was no shortage of vines to use as fuel for a fire, so I soon had a small, flickering light. After so much walking, my leg was almost giving out again.

My fire, though burning, was low and sputtering, as if in a breeze. No matter how many vines I placed on it, it wouldn't grow beyond a small, single flame.

I sighed, and decided it would be best to get some sleep. The first sun wouldn't rise for at least another eight hours, so I could rest for a while.

I had only been asleep for a few minutes when something startled me awake. The fire had gone out while I slept, and my surroundings were dark.

A crack. Something in the darkness slammed against the stone of the palace. I leapt up, using my cane as a lever, scanning the darkness for any signs of movement.

I found none. The shadows around my camp remained still, locked in place with the unmoving moon in the sky above. No sounds echoed from the wrecked rubble around me.

The End of Part I

Part II

Vibrant red light shone from behind me, reflecting off a wall. I blinked. Had I fallen asleep again? My back ached from sleeping against a wall. Just one more ache to add to the list. I scrabbled around for my cane, and used it to push myself mostly upright.

The first sun had risen, and the ruins were bathed in its flames of light. Under this new light I could see for certain that the sketches I had would be worthless here. Instead of searching the ruins for the armory, I would have to hope that what I sought was in the palace vaults.

As I looked for the best way into the palace I found another statue, halfway up a flight of stairs, holding a rusty sword. Had it been there when I arrived? And why was it also wearing a crown?

Trying to shake off the eerie feeling that someone was watching me, I continued into the palace ruins. Unlike the rest of the city, which had been torn asunder by whatever force wrecked it, the palace appeared to have been taken apart deliberately, as if someone was trying to understand how it had been constructed, or was searching for a single stone used in a wall. Clean cuts in the stone were visible in the rubble, and the fragments I found there were larger, almost too regular in size.

As I wandered deeper into the palace complex, I found more and more statues littered about. Most wore crowns; only those on plinths or set into the walls were without an iron circlet on their heads.

Inside a ring of metal spikes, the central stairs of the palace plunged deep into the earth. The actual stairs had collapsed, leaving a pit with jagged edges. There was no way I was climbing down that.

Ten minutes of digging through my notes later, I discovered a vague reference to a possible back entrance to the lower palace vaults from the lakeshore beneath the palace.

On the path down I passed a building with a tall tower on the left side, a circular window in the center, and a pile of blue dust which might once have been tiles. I took out my sketch, hoping that I had found the magician's residence out of pure luck.

Unfortunately, it didn't match. The door was placed wrong, and the dust I thought might have been roof tiles turned out to be a trick of the light.

I put the sketch away, dejected, and continued to the lakeside. The lake was dry, except for a few small streams running into it. Despite this, it remained near empty.

Vines grew thick over the small crack in the granite block that led to the vaults. Perhaps these growths had been present before the fall, protecting the location of the back entrance. A small trickle of water ran out of it into the near-dry lakebed at the foot of the cliffs.

I slipped inside, feeling the cool, dark air of the tunnel surround me, almost grabbing me. Pulling one of the illuminant rods I carried from my pack and snapping it alight, I gasped as I realized I was face-to-face with yet another statue.

This one wore no crown, but leered hideously from the shadows along the edges of the tunnel. An ancient deterrent?

The light creeping in through the entrance faded as I continued down the tunnel. Mist seeped out of cracks in the walls, surrounding me and cloaking yet more statues arrayed along the walls.

A door loomed out of the mists. Rusted metal bars rested across it, as if trying to lock something behind it. Why would someone try to lock the vault from the outside?

Wedging my light into the hand of a nearby statue, I shoved at the bars and they fell to the ground, shattering into thousands of rusted splinters. I went to retrieve my light, and found that it wouldn't move. The statue's hand had closed around it, locking it in place. I looked up and found an iron crown on the stone head, which featured an expression of pure terror.

I stumbled back, nearly falling as my leg flinched at the sudden movement. Had the statue moved? Or had I simply been careless in shoving my light into its hand?

I didn't wait around to find out. Drawing another light out of my satchel, I hurried into the room behind the now-open door, leaving the hall of statues behind.

The room inside was lit by veins of glowing crystal running through the walls. Statues stood in alcoves along the outside of the hexagonal room. A circular ring of water surrounded a small raised island in the center, and upon the dais...

Upon the dais stood a king. Blade shoved into the stone, robes falling around his shoulders, golden crown shining on his graven head.

I took a step forward and the ground clinked under my feet. Coins were strewn across the ground, along with gems, jewelry, and other valuables.

If this was the vault, however, it had already been ransacked. Despite the rumors, myths, and other haunted stories of this city, someone had come to loot it all the same.

I sat down on a fallen piece of stone, resting my legs from the long walk. My search was over, then. With no way of finding either fragment of the relic I sought, there was truly no hope for me.

The End of Part II

Part III

The air in the vault chilled. I turned towards the door to leave, and found it blocked by a stone soldier, crowned with iron. I froze. Had that been there when I entered? Had I squeezed past it without thinking, rushing to escape the cold darkness of the hallway?

Or...had I simply been ignoring something for too long. This city, my city, was home to something else now. And I should...join it?

Shocked, I found myself only a step away from the statue, my hand reaching for the crown resting on its head.

I ran. As much as the half-shuffle I could do was running. The tunnel felt a mile long as I hurried down it. My satchel fell from my shoulder, and I left it behind.

Shoving my way out between the vines over the entrance, I found the lake covered in the same cold mist from the tunnel. As I passed the obelisk on the southern bank, I slowed. Why was I running? Wasn't this where I was meant to be?

Resting at the base of the obelisk was another crown, made of cold, rusted iron. That was mine.

Again, I shook myself. What was I doing? The buildings were vanishing into the mists around me. Something cracked in the shadows behind me.

I hurried away from the obelisk and found myself at the edge of the water. Cursing, I spun and ran the other way, ignoring my screaming leg.

The mist swirled as I ran through it. Shattered buildings towered around me, looming like walls in a maze. I turned down what must have been a large road, and found a rift in the ground ahead of me.

I spun around, searching for another path. Left of the road was nothing but rubble. Right...

On the right a tall, nearly intact building towered over me. Tower on the left. Circular window set above the door. Blue roof tiles.

How ironic that only during my desperate flight to safety did I find the object of my search.